

CORE FORMULA

Notice the shift impulse -> support their thread -> invite one more detail -> share only if it adds value -> return to them. -> Short form: notice -> respond -> invite -> calibrate -> release. -> “That sounds rough — what part went wrong?” then actually listen before you relate. -> “I’ve been there too, but yours sounds like the bigger story. What happened?” -> “That’s a big one. What was the best bit?” — support the win before you match it.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before saying “That happened to me too”, say one support line first: “That sounds like a lot — what happened next?”

BEST FOR

- Someone shares news, stress, an achievement, disappointment or story
- You feel a strong urge to say “me too”
- You want reciprocity without taking over
- A friend is venting and you want to help without redirecting
- Responding to good or bad news without competing
- Group conversations where quick hijacks are common

PHRASE BANK

Quick and digital · Short, text-length support

- "What happened next?"
- "How did that land?"
- "That makes sense."
- "Tell me the key bit."
- "What was that like?"
- "Go on — I'm listening."
- "That's a lot."
- "Oof, that's rough — what happened?"
- "Nice one. What made it work?"
- "Say more?"

Warmth and acknowledgement · Social / support / validation

- "That sounds intense — what was that like?"
- "That is a big one. What happened next?"
- "I can see why that stuck with you."
- "Before I jump in with my version, tell me the best part."
- "That sounds like a lot to carry."
- "No wonder that stayed with you."
- "I'm really glad that worked out — what was the best of it?"
- "That sounds like it mattered to you."
- "Take your time. I want to hear it."

Work and meetings · Professional / client / decision

- "That sounds like it took real effort. What was the key obstacle?"
- "That is useful context. What did you decide from there?"

- "Before I add my experience, what mattered most in your case?"
- "That's a real result. What made the difference?"
- "Sounds like a tough call — what tipped it?"
- "I've seen something similar, but I'd rather hear your read first."
- "That's helpful background. What did you weigh up?"

Invite one more detail · Draw the thread out

- "What part went wrong?"
- "What was the hardest bit?"
- "What made it work?"
- "What was the turning point?"
- "What mattered most to you in that?"
- "What happened after that?"
- "What are you making of it now?"
- "What's the part you're still turning over?"

Hand the floor back · Recovery / return the thread

- "Actually, your bit is the important one here."
- "Let me stay with your point for a second."
- "Before I jump in with mine, tell me the rest."
- "I'll tell my version later — what happened with yours?"
- "Sorry, that was me taking over. Go on."
- "I don't want to bulldoze your story. Keep going."
- "I meant to relate, not take over."

When it's tense or raw · Distress or high pressure

- "That sounds genuinely hard. I'm here — what do you need right now?"
- "Let's stay with what happened to you first."
- "I'm not going to make this about me. Go on."
- "That's a lot to hold. Take your time."
- "You don't have to rush it. What happened?"
- "I hear how much this got to you."
- "Whatever I've been through can wait — this is about you."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Same thing happened to me. (Shifts straight to yourself and can feel like a hijack.)
Better: That sounds familiar — what happened next? (Acknowledges the link but keeps their thread alive.)
Best: I've got a related story, but yours sounds like the important bit. What was the turning point? (Names the reciprocity while protecting their moment.)
- Weak: Oh, I did that last year. (Turns their win into your anecdote.)
Better: That's a great result — how did you pull it off? (Celebrates before relating.)
Best: That's brilliant. What was the best part for you? I've done something similar, but I want to hear yours first. (Support, invite, then reciprocity.)
- Weak: You think that's bad, let me tell you about my week. (Competes with their stress.)
Better: That sounds draining. What was the worst of it? (Stays on their thread.)
Best: That sounds genuinely hard. Talk me through it — I won't turn it into my own saga. (Support with a light, honest reassurance.)

DECISION TREE

If You feel a self-story rising

Pause and support their thread first.

""That sounds like a lot — what happened next?""

If They asked about your experience

Share briefly, then return the floor to them.

“I’ve had something like it, but tell me how yours ended.”

If They are giving short answers

Stop probing; offer a reciprocal contribution or a graceful exit.

“No pressure to get into it — I just wanted to check in.”

If Your story is bigger than theirs

Hold it back unless it clearly helps them.

“Yours is the one that matters here. What was the turning point?”

If They have finished and turned to you

Share your related bit, then hand the thread back.

“That reminds me of something similar — but first, how are you feeling about it?”

SCENARIOS

A friend shares a stressful day

Support the stress thread before mentioning your own day. — *“That sounds exhausting. What was the worst part?”*

A colleague shares a win

Ask what made it work before offering your similar project. — *“That’s a great result — what made the difference?”*

Text or DM exchange

Send one support line before any related anecdote. — *“Oof, that’s rough — what happened?”*

Group conversation after a pile-on

Hand the floor back to the original speaker once others have jumped in. — *“Wait — I want to hear how yours actually ended.”*

Someone shares bad news

Acknowledge and slow down before relating anything of your own. — *“I’m really sorry. How are you holding up?”*

You genuinely have a strong “me too”

Support and invite first, then offer your version briefly and hand back. — *“I’ve been through something like that. But tell me yours first — what happened?”*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The other person directly asks about your experience
- The conversation has clearly moved into mutual exchange
- Your own disclosure is urgent or safety-relevant
- You are using support lines to stall or avoid saying what you actually mean
- Physical safety or an emergency needs a direct response first
- You have nothing genuine to relate and a support line would sound hollow

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the impulse

Through one ordinary day, silently tally each time you feel the urge to jump in with your own story. Change nothing else — just notice how often the shift impulse fires.

Day 2 — Name three moments

Write three real situations from the past week where a shift response would have hijacked the moment. For each, note what a single support line could have been instead.

Day 3 — Build the ladder

For each of the three, write a weak line, a better line and a best line — support first, then invite, then optional reciprocity that still hands the floor back.

Day 4 — Say it short

Say each best line aloud twice, then cut it by about a third so it sounds like ordinary speech rather than a script. Bin any line that sounds clever or coached.

Day 5 — Field test, low stakes

In one easy conversation, use the minimum viable move once: one support line before any “me too”. Afterwards, record what the other person did in response.

Day 6 — Invite one more detail

In two conversations, add exactly one invite question after your support line, then genuinely wait — no relating anything of your own until they’ve fully answered.

Day 7 — Reciprocity, then hand back

Use the full move once: support, invite, share your related bit briefly, then return the floor with a question. Note where it felt natural and where it felt forced.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I support their thread before reaching for my own story?
- Did I use plain language rather than a script?
- Did I keep their autonomy intact — no pressure, no steering?
- Did I stop after one move instead of overusing it?
- Did I use a recovery line if I jumped in too fast?
- Did the exchange feel easier afterwards, or more self-conscious?